

Chapter 44 - Testing

When the three arrived at their booked hotel, it was still early. They had left early and hadn't gotten stuck in traffic much on the way, so they arrived at their destination smoothly.

Fenggu Lake Resort was located at the border between Beijing and the neighboring city, a tourist development area famous for Fenggu Lake Hot Springs and holiday fireworks shows, attracting many visitors.

Especially during statutory holidays like Golden Week, tourists were countless.

Feng Yue and her friends arrived early, but the resort was already bustling with people coming and going.

However, they had already booked their accommodation in advance, so now they just needed to check in with their luggage.

This trip was entirely arranged by Wen Zhen, and out of absolute trust in Wen Zhen, Feng Yue and Zhou Qiongqiong barely worried about anything.

Wen Zhen had booked a guesthouse in an excellent location within the resort, with the landlord being a young girl.

Zhou Qiongqiong, refreshed after her nap, went forward to chat familiarly with the landlord.

Through chatting, they learned that this young-looking girl was the landlord of this entire area of guesthouses they had booked, owning about 20 properties of various sizes.

Even though the three came from good backgrounds, they were stunned by these 20 properties.

Zhou Qiongqiong was even more amazed: "How wonderful, isn't this exactly the career I've always dreamed of? Being a landlady, not having to work exhaustingly at a job, just waiting to collect rent."

The girl smiled, revealing a single dimple at the corner of her mouth: "Running guesthouses is also very tiring. We often encounter tourists with no manners."

"Once there were seven or eight young people traveling together who booked our house. When I went to collect the room after they left, it was completely like a husky had passed through¹—as messy as possible. The kitchen was the disaster area, they had hotpot the night before, and the soup base was spilled all over the floor, oily and dirty."

Zhou Qiongqiong looked sympathetic: "You should have collected a deposit, right? For cases like that, just don't refund it."

The girl smiled bitterly: "I'd rather refund their deposit than have them mess up the house with dirt and chaos."

"That's true too."

Chatting as they walked, they reached the guesthouse entrance. The girl gave them the keys and then left.

The guesthouse had two floors, with three bedrooms upstairs and a living room and kitchen downstairs.

The guesthouse was decorated very warmly, and the small items inside made the whole house look less cold and more humane.

Their car was parked in the resort's unified parking lot, so now that they had found their accommodation, they needed to go get their luggage.

"Qiongqiong and I will go get it. You wait in the house." Wen Zhen put down her bag and took off her cumbersome outer coat, handing it to Feng Yue.

Zhou Qiongqiong also nodded in agreement: "Right, didn't you say your stomach was uncomfortable? Rest here, Sister and I will be quick."

The two didn't give Feng Yue a chance to refuse. After speaking, they left the guesthouse side by side.

Feng Yue had no choice but to start wandering around the house, checking if there was anything that shouldn't be there.

Zhou Qiongqiong and Wen Zhen moved quickly, reaching the parking lot area in no time.

Zhou Qiongqiong struggled to drag her suitcase out of the car's trunk while Wen Zhen carried luggage for both herself and Feng Yue with both hands.

"You two only brought this much?" Zhou Qiongqiong looked at the considerable difference in their luggage and smiled somewhat embarrassedly.

"Ah Yue and I only brought changes of clothes, unlike you who practically moved your entire home here." Wen Zhen teased her with a smile.

Zhou Qiongqiong coughed lightly to cover her embarrassment: "Hey, I was thinking everyone could use these things. What I brought is equivalent to what you brought!"

"Alright, let's go."

The return trip wasn't as light and easy as when they came empty-handed. Zhou Qiongqiong's suitcase was indeed quite heavy, so Wen Zhen slowed her pace to match her.

Slowing down made Zhou Qiongqiong unable to control her mouth—she always wanted to chat about something.

"Sister, haven't you noticed you've been acting strange lately?" Zhou Qiongqiong's words seemed somewhat inexplicable.

Wen Zhen was also puzzled: "Hm? How have I been strange?"

Zhou Qiongqiong glanced at her and quickly looked away: "Cough, how should I put it? I just feel like you've become a bit closer to me than before."

Wen Zhen was stunned and began thinking carefully.

Actually, she and Zhou Qiongqiong weren't that close before. After all, her mother was the theater troupe's director with countless disciples under her. For Wen Zhen to be close to everyone was almost impossible.

So previously she was only politely distant, often buying food to treat everyone at the theater troupe, but nothing more than that.

Zhou Qiongqiong was one of her mother's more talented disciples, reaching the principal position in just a few years. As Zhou Qiongqiong's interactions with her mother increased, her contact with Wen Zhen gradually increased too.

So Zhou Qiongqiong was probably the person closest to her in the theater troupe, but that was all.

If someone had told Wen Zhen before that she would go on vacation with Zhou Qiongqiong in the future, she absolutely wouldn't have believed it.

Seeing Wen Zhen remain silent, Zhou Qiongqiong continued: "Actually, I can feel it too. Sister became closer to me because of Ah Yue's appearance."

"So, Sister, you wouldn't happen to..." Zhou Qiongqiong didn't finish her sentence completely, then used her peripheral vision to observe Wen Zhen's reaction.

Hearing this, Wen Zhen looked down and smiled slightly: "Yes."

Zhou Qiongqiong's guess was confirmed by the person herself, and her heart started racing: "You really have feelings for Ah Yue?"

"Mm."

"The romantic kind?"

"Mm."

Zhou Qiongqiong's face turned completely red, whether from holding her breath or something else. She reached out and heavily patted the handle of her suitcase: "I knew it!"

Wen Zhen smiled, waiting with interest for Zhou Qiongqiong to continue.

"Sister, you're super gentle with people, but I always felt you were surrounded by an aura of aloofness. But when facing Ah Yue, you don't have that feeling at all! Your gentleness toward her is genuine—the kind where you'd patiently indulge her!"

"Am I that obvious?" Wen Zhen's eyebrows were tinged with amusement.

"Actually, it's okay, I just have good intuition. I always felt you treated Ah Yue differently than you treat me." Zhou Qiongqiong smiled, reaching out to link arms with Wen Zhen: "Sister, don't worry, I'll definitely help you pursue Ah Yue!"

"Someone as wonderful as Ah Yue should have someone who cherishes her."

Wen Zhen was curious: "How so?"

As Feng Yue and Yan Lin's high school classmate, Zhou Qiongqiong knew some but not all of their story: "I was classmates with Feng Yue and Yan Lin in high school. Yan Lin is Ah Yue's ex-wife—you remember, we had dinner together."

"I remember, continue."

"Yan Lin and Feng Yue were two prominent figures in our school back then. To be honest, they met because of me." Zhou Qiongqiong then told Wen Zhen about how Feng Yue and Yan Lin met and how Feng Yue began pursuing Yan Lin.

"After the college entrance exam, I only remember they went to the same university and major, then I wasn't sure about the rest. I participate in organizing our high school reunion every year. This year's reunion was the first time they both attended, and that's when I learned they had gotten married. I was touched by their good relationship at the time, but who would have thought they'd divorce within a few months."

Zhou Qiongqiong still felt wistful talking about this—she was probably someone who witnessed how their relationship began and how it ended.

"So, someone as devoted as Ah Yue should be paired with a partner who cherishes and loves her. Because she's the type who, once she's decided on you, won't give up unless it's something major. Sister, if you can be with Ah Yue, I'll definitely give you a big red envelope²!"

Wen Zhen laughed: "You're thinking quite far ahead. Ah Yue doesn't even know I like her yet."

Wen Zhen spoke and then looked down, sighing somewhat wistfully: "She probably just sees me as a good friend."

"That's true, but she just got divorced, so it's understandable." Zhou Qiongqiong also frowned slightly, then relaxed her expression: "Sister, I believe where there's a will, there's a way. Keep going, you can definitely do it!"

"Alright."

The two chatted and laughed, quickly reaching the guesthouse. But before they arrived, they saw Feng Yue waiting at the door.

Seeing the two figures, Feng Yue ran up to them with bright smiling eyes, reaching out to take the luggage from Wen Zhen's hands: "If you didn't come back soon, I was going to look for you. I thought the parking lot was pretty close to here."

As she spoke, Feng Yue's gaze fell on Zhou Qiongqiong's suitcase, instantly understanding why the two had been so slow. She slowly gave Zhou Qiongqiong a look and shook her head.

"What!" Zhou Qiongqiong understood that slightly disgusted look: "Isn't walking slowly good? I was being considerate of Sister by walking just a tiny bit slower."

"Yes, yes, yes, Sister Wen Zhen should walk a bit slower." Feng Yue smiled without arguing, as if coaxing a child.

"Mm, indeed." Wen Zhen even seriously agreed.

Zhou Qiongqiong: ...

I feel like I'm being targeted, but I have no evidence.

The three took their luggage to their respective rooms to settle in, then returned to the downstairs living room to sit.

After the journey, Zhou Qiongqiong, who hadn't eaten breakfast, was already starving.

It was almost mealtime now, so the three tidied up and prepared to go out for food.

When the landlord girl had brought them over earlier, Zhou Qiongqiong had asked about good restaurants nearby.

The girl had most recommended a luxuriously decorated restaurant. They were shocked at the time, saying shouldn't the best food be in those run-down little shops?

The girl had simply said: "Good restaurants have good business, so they make more money. When they have the means, they naturally improve their dining environment too. Don't let those online opinions PUA³ you. Almost all restaurants that can open here with good business won't taste bad, so you can randomly pick a crowded one and won't go wrong."

After hearing this, the three had an epiphany, so now they headed straight for the luxuriously decorated restaurant the girl had mentioned.

Because it was close to mealtime and Golden Week, the restaurant was very crowded, mostly groups of people.

A server led the three into the restaurant, but then Feng Yue heard a familiar voice calling from behind her.

"Miss Feng?"

Footnotes:

¹ 像哈士奇过境 - Like a husky had passed through - A humorous Chinese internet expression comparing a messy room to the destruction a husky (known for being destructive) might cause.

² 红包 (red envelope) - Traditional monetary gifts given during celebrations, weddings, etc. in Chinese culture.

³ PUA - Pick-up Artist tactics, but in this context refers to manipulative messaging that makes people doubt themselves or accept lower standards.